

A Web Design Pipeline

A strategy-first pipeline for designing a website, combining the requirements workflow discussed earlier with a strategy-before-design production process

This pipeline treats a website as something you design the way you would design any system with real stakeholders: start from the problem, gather real needs, decide what deserves to be built, only then move into brand strategy, content, and visuals. It also builds in a strategy-first production approach: research and a strategy meeting happen before any design work, content is collected through standardized templates rather than chased page by page, and the build stage uses components and site-wide styles so changes can be made once and apply everywhere, rather than rebuilding a mockup and then a separate coded site.

Phase 0: Ground the Problem

Before touching any page, layout, or brand direction, write down what the website is actually for. This anchors every later decision.

- Write a one-paragraph purpose statement: **what this website is for, and what it should let a visitor decide or do**
- Ask why this website is needed at least three times, to get past the surface reason to the real root cause
- **Define what success looks like in measurable terms if possible, such as inquiries, purchases, signups, or trust built before a sale happens elsewhere**
- Set explicit scope boundaries: what this website will not try to do or be

Phase 1: Identify Everyone Involved

List everyone who will touch the site or care about it, split into three groups:

- Users: the people who will directly visit and use the site
- Stakeholders: people who care about the outcome but will not browse it themselves, such as the business owner, investors, or regulators
- Affected parties: people impacted indirectly, such as support staff who answer questions the site should have already answered

For each group, note their level of influence and level of interest. This becomes a simple grid that decides who gets interviewed first, and later, which page needs to speak to which group.

Phase 2: Strategic Planning, Before Any Design Work Understand their tone

This is the stage a lot of web projects skip. Research and a strategy meeting come before design, because strategy is what increases the value of the final site and shortens the project timeline overall.

Research and Brand Questionnaire

- Send a structured brand questionnaire before the strategy meeting, so the business owner arrives with their answers already thought through rather than answering on the spot
- Use the questionnaire to surface the same raw material the complaint-gathering step needs: how the business currently operates, what has not worked, what customers ask or misunderstand most often

Brand Messaging

- Build a narrative using a story script: who the customer is, what problem they face, how the business helps them solve it, and what the transformation looks like after

- This narrative becomes the backbone for headline copy, page order, and which content categories matter most later in the content phase

Competitor Analysis

- Identify the industry leaders and direct competitors
- Use this to position the client clearly: where they should look similar to build trust in the category, and where they should look different to stand out

Creative Direction

- Establish a mood board, photography style, and visual identity early, so both designer and client are aligned on look and feel before any page is built
- This prevents the common failure mode of building full pages, then discovering the visual direction was never actually agreed on

Marketing and Website Strategy

- Decide how the website fits into the client's marketing funnel before designing pages. A location-based business needs SEO-structured pages built to be found; a business driving traffic from social media needs high-converting sales pages built to close, not to be discovered
- This decision changes page priority, page structure, and even which pages get built at all, so it belongs in strategy, not left as an assumption during design

Phase 3: Gather Needs and Classify Them

With the brand questionnaire and strategy meeting as primary input, treat this like real requirement gathering, not a guess about what looks nice.

- Collect from multiple channels: the brand questionnaire, the strategy meeting, past customer questions or support requests, and competitor gaps found during the competitor analysis
- Capture everything in the client's own words first, do not clean it up or interpret it yet
- Cluster similar needs together, and note how many separate sources point to the same thing
- Classify each as alloplastic, something the website genuinely needs to provide or fix, autoplactic, something better solved by clearer messaging or guidance rather than a structural feature, or mixed, a combination of both, with the tradeoff written down explicitly

Phase 4: Convert to Page and Content Requirements

Turn the surviving, alloplastic and mixed-resolved items into concrete, buildable requirements.

- Rewrite each as one atomic requirement, one sentence, one requirement
- Classify each as functional, such as a booking system or contact form, or non-functional, such as load time or mobile responsiveness
- Attach an acceptance criterion to each: how you would verify it is actually met once built
- Prioritize with MoSCoW: Must have, Should have, Could have, Won't have, informed directly by the marketing and website strategy decision from Phase 2
- Strip vague words like modern or professional, and replace them with the concrete direction set by the mood board and creative direction work

Phase 5: Design Around the Website as a Space

A website is not a poster, a book, or a newspaper. It is closer to a space a visitor enters and moves through, rather than an object they passively receive. Every page-level decision should be checked against this.

- Wayfinding over reading: visitors scan for landmarks first, a logo, a nav bar, a clear primary action, before reading anything closely
- Agency and control: never trap the visitor. Avoid autoplay video, forced signup walls, or hidden ways to go back
- Trust is spatial before verbal: visual polish and layout are judged before any text is read, which is exactly why creative direction and mood boards are locked in Phase 2, before content or code
- Liveness: a site should visibly look current. Stale dates, broken links, or outdated info reads as abandonment, which damages trust even if the offer is still valid

Phase 6: Content Collection, Using Standardized Templates

Content gathering is usually the slowest, most painful part of a project. Standardized copy templates keep it organized rather than open-ended.

- Build one copy template per page type, homepage, about, services, contact, so the client fills in structured fields instead of writing free-form paragraphs
- Base each template's structure on the content categories a page actually needs, not a blank document

Content Categories, by the Psychological Job They Do

Legitimacy signals, answers is this real:

- About or team information, physical address or location, years in business, credentials or certifications, press mentions or partner logos

Social proof, answers do other people trust this:

- Testimonials, reviews, case studies, usage numbers, client logos

Orientation content, answers am I in the right place, what do I do here:

- A clear one-line value statement above the fold, built from the story script in Phase 2, visual hierarchy showing the primary action versus secondary information, navigation that shows the visitor where they are

Risk reduction, answers what happens if this goes wrong:

- FAQ, return or refund policy, guarantee, contact information, support availability

Depth for the undecided, answers I am not ready to act yet, but I want to understand more:

- How it works content, comparisons, detailed feature explanation, blog or resource content

Not every page needs every category. A high-converting sales page from social traffic mainly needs orientation, social proof, and risk reduction stacked tightly. An SEO-structured page for local search needs legitimacy and depth content to rank and to satisfy a colder visitor.

Content Requirements Table

Build one table across the whole site with these columns: Page, Visitor type, Question they need answered, Content element, Priority. This makes content collection traceable instead of a guess, and each template from this phase maps directly onto one row group in the table.

Phase 7: Structure the Design Specification

Before visual build work starts, assemble a specification that ties strategy, requirements, and content together.

- Introduction: purpose, scope, and terms, taken from Phase 0

- Brand and strategy summary: story script, competitor positioning, mood board direction, and funnel strategy from Phase 2
- Specific requirements: the functional and non-functional requirements from Phase 4, organized by page
- Content requirements: the table from Phase 6
- Traceability: link every requirement and content element back to the need that produced it, and to the visitor group it serves
- Sitemap and page hierarchy: derived from the pages needed to serve the funnel strategy and the content requirements table
- Wireframes: a rough layout per page showing where each content category sits, built before any visual styling

Phase 8: Build with Components and Site-Wide Styles

Design and development happen as one continuous stage rather than two separate steps. A tool like Framer supports this well: it offers full design freedom and responsive behavior directly, so there is no separate handoff from a static mockup to a coded build.

- Set up site-wide styles first, such as color, typography, and spacing, so they apply everywhere at once rather than being set page by page
- Build reusable components for repeating elements such as buttons, navigation, and content sections

Components: Speed and Consistency

The main benefit of components in a tool like Framer is that they deliver speed and design consistency across the whole site at once, rather than page by page.

- Global updates: modifying a component automatically applies that change to every instance of it throughout the design. This is especially efficient for frequently repeated elements like navigation bars, footers, and buttons
- Streamlined workflow: setting up standard sections as components removes the need to manually update every page individually, so a site-wide design change happens in seconds rather than hours
- Flexibility: if one page needs a unique version of a section, such as different testimonials on a sales page versus the homepage, detach that specific instance from the component. This customizes that one section without affecting the global component everywhere else it is used
- Use templates for common, well-understood features rather than building every element from a blank canvas. Custom design does not require building from scratch, templates handle the predictable parts so effort concentrates on the strategy and details that are actually unique to this client
- Build pages in priority order, following the Must-have, Should-have, Could-have order set in Phase 4
- Keep the primary action visually dominant on every page, consistent with the wayfinding and agency principles from Phase 5
- No coding knowledge is required to deliver a high-quality, high-converting site this way. What clients value is functionality and speed, not whether the build was hand-coded

Why Templates Work, Not Just a Shortcut

Templates are sometimes seen as a compromise on quality. In this pipeline they are treated as a deliberate efficiency tool, with four specific benefits:

- Focusing on strategy: using templates for repetitive tasks such as standard pages or common site sections frees up time for the work that actually differentiates the project, brand strategy, messaging, and custom solutions built around the client's specific goals

- Consistency and speed: templates for foundational elements such as navigation bars, footers, and content structures create a faster, more streamlined workflow, especially when paired with components and global styles as described in this phase
- Avoiding blank slate syndrome: starting every project from a fully empty canvas is where the blank page problem from Phase 6 tends to reappear at the build level. Templates provide a proven, high-converting foundation, which minimizes time spent on technical setup and keeps attention on the unique aesthetic and functional needs of this specific client
- Reducing revisions: because essential components and structure are planned and agreed on early, during Phase 7's specification and wireframes, there is less back-and-forth and fewer extensive revisions once the build is underway

Phase 9: Review, Test, and Sign Off

- Walk through each page against the content requirements table: confirm every listed visitor question actually has an answer visible on the page
- Check each page against the funnel strategy decided in Phase 2: an SEO page should read differently from a social-traffic sales page
- Test with a few real people from each visitor group identified in Phase 1, watching where they hesitate or look for something that is not there
- Revisit the autoplastic items from Phase 3: confirm the site now clarifies or guides around them rather than leaving the visitor to guess
- Get sign-off from at least one representative of each stakeholder group before launch

Phase 10: Maintain Liveness

A website is judged as current unless it visibly proves otherwise, so this is an ongoing phase, not a one-time step.

- Because the build uses shared components and site-wide styles, updates to buttons, navigation, or repeated sections can be made once and apply across the whole site immediately, except on pages where a section was deliberately detached to stay unique, which need updating on their own
- Review dated content, testimonials, and pricing on a regular schedule so nothing reads as abandoned
- Feed new real-world questions and objections back into Phase 3, so the site keeps evolving from real input rather than assumptions
- Revisit the priority table periodically, since a Should-have or Could-have item can become a Must-have as the business or its visitors change

Summary of the Pipeline

- Ground the problem
- Identify everyone involved
- Strategic planning: research, brand questionnaire, story script, competitor analysis, creative direction, funnel strategy
- Gather needs and classify as alloplastic, autoplastic, or mixed
- Convert to page and content requirements
- Design around the website as a space
- Content collection using standardized templates, solving the blank page problem
- Structure the design specification
- Build with components, site-wide styles, and templates, freeing time for strategy and reducing revisions

- Review, test, and sign off
- Maintain liveness